Gifted

By Simon Rich

When the nurses handed me my son, I couldn't believe how perfect he was. Ben was so robust, nearly fifty inches tall, including horns and tail. Even the doula was impressed.

"My God," she said. "My holy God in heaven."

Alan and I knew instantly that our child was exceptional. He was just so adorable, with his pentagram birthmark and little, grasping claws. His red eyes gleamed with intelligence. When the doctors came in with all their charts, they just confirmed what we already knew. Our child was "one of a kind" and "unlike any creature born of man."

INTRODUCTION

It's a natural instinct to want to help your child. After all, that's what parents do: We protect and support our children until they are ready to go out on their own. But these days some parents are defining "protect" and "support" a little differently than usual. And the definition of when kids are ready to be on their own has gotten fuzzy, too.

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Compound this social phenomenon with being the parent of a differently-abled child, author Simon Rich and you get a short story rife with hyperbole entitled . . . . Gifted

Alan and I were ecstatic – but also a little bit nervous. Raising a gifted child is a huge responsibility. We vowed then and there that we would do all we could to ensure he achieved his full potential.

The first step was getting him into the right preschool. We figured it would be a breeze, given Ben's obvious star quality. But, to our great surprise, he struggled. At Trevor Day, a teacher asked him how old he was. Instead of saying "three," he pinned her to the ceiling with his mind. We were able to get him an interview at Trinity, thanks to a family connection. But when Ben saw the crucifix in the lobby, his eyes turned black and the walls wept blood. Why was Ben behaving this way?

There was only one logical explanation: attention deficit disorder. We took him to a specialist on Park

Avenue, and within five minutes our son had his first prescription for Ritalin.

At first Ben wouldn't take his pills. Padma, our nanny, had to chase him for hours around the apartment, blowing incense in the air to try to scare him down from the ceiling. Within months, though, Ben got used to his medication. He became calmer, more alert, and far less murderous. He was a real joy to be around.

In some ways, Ben still lagged behind most children. He spoke only one word: *arrgh*. And he was unable to tie his shoes or blink his eyes. We didn't care, though. Because, by the age of five, he'd finally found an outlet for his gifts. Art!

Ben always had a creative temperament. He could grip crayons by his second birthday (which is very rare), and by the age of six he was drawing every day. His favorite colors were black and red. Sometimes, while composing a sketch, he would become so excited that his crayon would break apart in his claws and he would start to ram his horns against the wall as noxious steam emitted from his ears. If Ben's art supplies were taken

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from him, he would respond with so much violence that Padma would have to subdue him, using one of the sleeper holds she'd learned. It didn't take long for Alan and me to realize we had a true artiste on our hands.

We decided to enroll Ben at Dalton, because of its emphasis on creativity. I wasn't going to let Ben's talent go to waste at some cookie-cutter public school where every child is forced into the same dull mold. I wanted him to have a chance to find himself.

Ben's time at Dalton was not without incident. He's incredibly unique – every teacher said so. But his creativity could sometimes be a burden. If a subject didn't 'grab' him, he would have trouble focusing – and instead create a game of his own design. For example, in fifth grade, a teacher asked him to calculate the area of a four-by-six-foot rectangle. Instead of multiplying four by six, as a typical child might have done, Ben crab-walked across the ceiling and blinded the teacher with a fire stare. The incident was very traumatic for our son. Alan and I decided it was time to reexamine his treatment.

After consulting with our specialist, we chose to switch Ben from Ritalin to Focalin, which is a slightly stronger medicine. We also hired Han Cho, an astrophysics PhD candidate at Columbia, to tutor Ben five days a week after school.

The sad truth is, our world is just not designed for differently abled children. Many assignments at Dalton require the use of pencils, which Ben cannot hold in his claw. Other projects involve calculators, which Ben considers food, or the use of English, which Ben cannot speak. Enlisting Han allowed Ben to complete his assignments at his own pace and in a way that showcased his distinct gifts.

Ben's grades soon improved. We were so grateful to Han for unlocking our son's potential. Once, they were studying vocab by the pool when I heard a loud splashing noise. When I went outside to check on them, Ben was holding Han upside down by the ankles and growling with delight.

"Help!" Han shouted, playing along with Ben's game. "I've lost control! I've lost control!"

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When Ben turned thirteen, we knew it was time to start thinking about college. We met with a number of counseling firms. They helped us structure a four-year strategy for Ben that would demonstrate his skill set – and we followed the plan to the letter. By the time Ben was a senior, his résumé was absolutely glittering. He'd received five participation gavels from Model UN, been elected tri-captain of the Dalton golf team, and contributed numerous drawings to the school's Fine Arts Magazine. His GPA was a respectable 1.4, and even though he'd accidentally eaten several sections of his SAT he still managed to notch a 420.

Despite all of Ben's achievements, he did not seem excited about college. He'd spend hours in his room, playing violent video games. The only time I'd see Ben was late at night, when he'd emerge from his room to raid the fridge for Popsicles. I worked to take advantage of these 'sightings' as best I could. But when I tried to engage him in conversations about his future, he replied in typical teenage fashion, with a series of shrugs, grunts, and monosyllables.

"Do you want to go to a big school or a small school?"

"Arrgh."

"Do you want to be in a city or in the country?"

"Arrgh."

"Would you prefer lecture classes or seminars?"

"Arrgggh!!!!"

It was exasperating. In the end, we were able to persuade Ben to apply early to Bard. Alan and I had taken him there on a college tour and we were so impressed that we donated several tennis courts to their campus. When Ben was accepted, Alan and I were beside ourselves! But Ben wasn't as thrilled as you'd expect. Here he was, accepted into his dream school, and his smile was so faint I could barely see his fangs. It was obvious what had happened: Ben had burned out.

We met with Ben's psychiatrist and decided it would be best for him to take a 'gap year'. The only question was: where would Ben go? It was difficult to decide. He had his heart set on Transylvania, which I found baffling. (Italy would make more sense, since it

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has such a grand artistic tradition.) In the end, we compromised. Ben would spend two weeks on his own in Transylvania, as a reward for all his hard work. Then he'd spend six months at a wonderful program I found in Costa Rica that builds eco-friendly houses for the poor.

When Ben returned from his time abroad, he was a changed man. He had a swagger to his step and a confidence I'd never seen before. Part of me wondered if he'd maybe met a girlfriend overseas, but I knew better than to ask. If there's one thing I've learned from my years as a parent, it's that the mother is always the last to know!

Unfortunately, though, Ben had trouble adjusting to college. He thrived within his major, creating dozens of 'splatter' paintings in the Abstract Expressionist tradition. But he had difficulty with his core curriculum courses. Once, during a Spanish midterm, he escaped into the Hudson Valley woods and lived as a beast for several months, taking residence in a cave and eating neighborhood pets to survive. The local authorities were able to subdue him. And, thankfully, they turned him

over to the Bard police, so that his outburst could be handled internally by the school. But the event was traumatic for Ben, and I decided it would be best for him to take a semester off. We also got him a prescription for Adderall, which is a slightly stronger medicine than Focalin.

It took nearly seven years, but Ben eventually earned his BA in painting. I'll never forget how handsome he looked on the podium, with his cute little horns poking out through his mortarboard. No sooner had he snatched his diploma, though, than my heart began to race. All I could think was, *What now?*

We got him a prescription for Kilmax, which is a slightly stronger medicine than Adderall. Then, on a rainy February morning, I sat down with him to talk about his future. As usual, it was difficult for us to connect.

"Would you like us to rent you your own artist's studio in Williamsburg?"

"Arrgh."

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The Kilmax, I noticed, had produced several troubling side effects. Ben's eyes – usually so bright and searing – had dimmed to a pale ocher. His horns were pointed downward and his fur was falling out in clumps. I was telling him about another option – the birthright trip to Israel – when he suddenly held up his claw, cutting me off midsentence.

"No… more."

I screamed for Alan, and he came running. "Ben spoke!" I cried. We leaned in toward our son, keeping as still as possible. Ben gasped a few times, obviously struggling. Eventually, though, he managed to continue.

"No more… arrrrrgh! Pleeeeeaseeeearrrrrgh! Me… not… sick. Me… arrrrrrrgh! Monster. Let… be… monster. Let be monster."

My eyes filled with tears. I'd always assumed that Ben would never talk – and now here he was, carrying on a full conversation! If Ben could master language, there was no limit to what he could achieve. I whipped out my iPhone and typed in Han's number from memory.

It was time to start thinking about law school.

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